

Schrader's *Mishima*:

Sublime Masculinity and Transgressive Performance

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Paul Schrader's *Mishima: A Life in Four Chapters* is a complex film that weaves three distinct modes of representation together: memory, reality, and fantasy. Through this mixed approach of storytelling, Schrader's film constructs a psychobiographical account of the titular Yukio Mishima's life and eventual ritual suicide by seppuku. Yukio Mishima, pen-name of Kimitake Hiraoka, was a modernist author and far-right nationalist who attempted a coup of postwar Japan in the name of rearmament and a return to feudal principles; after the coup failed, he took his own life. Schrader's film seeks a kind of psychological clarity on the part of Mishima's worldview and drive towards death. By spinning together Mishima's memories with adaptations of three of his novels, told alongside his final day alive, the film attempts to contextualize his suicide as an enactment of a fantasy fundamental to his fetishized sense of masculinity. This fantasy is in large part rooted in a deeply misogynistic gendering of "weakness" and Mishima's desire to reclaim his masculinity in spite of the forces of reality that "effeminize" him. Mishima's reclamation of an ideal masculinity necessarily relies on the fantasy of death: to be masculine, Mishima must perform as a subject capable of striving against death, and in order to make that performance a reality, he must use death to concretize the performance in the physical and social world. However, despite how much the film's own form and structure represent the potential for fantasy and performance to bleed into the real, Mishima is ultimately devoured by his fetish, and his image of transcendental masculinity is incapable of a full translation into social reality.

In order to analyze the psychobiographical details of Mishima in this film, this paper will attempt to weave together information and sources about the real Yukio Mishima to fill in psychological gaps. However, the analysis itself is only considered with the film's representation and understanding of Mishima's psychology, which in itself is concerned with the real events of

his life, and even uses Mishima's own writings as a form of narration. This analysis will contend with the psychology of Schrader's Mishima, primarily focusing on the gendered conceptions of identity and reality that structure Mishima's engagement with the world, and that lead to his eventual death at the end of the film.

At the beginning of *Mishima: A Life in Four Chapters*, after the first chapter's title card, "beauty," the film opens up with a scene of Mishima getting ready the morning before his failed coup d'état of the Japanese military, and following death by seppuku. The first shot of this chapter looks up at Mishima's estate from the back of his garden, placing the back of a marble sculpture of Apollo in the center frame. This static shot cuts to another static shot of an empty hallway on the edge of his garden, with the door to Mishima's home at the end of it, and then back to the garden, yet overlooking it this time, above Apollo, who now faces the camera, yet still rests in the center frame. We get one more shot of the furniture in the garden before transitioning inside of the house to Mishima's bedroom, where his final day starts.

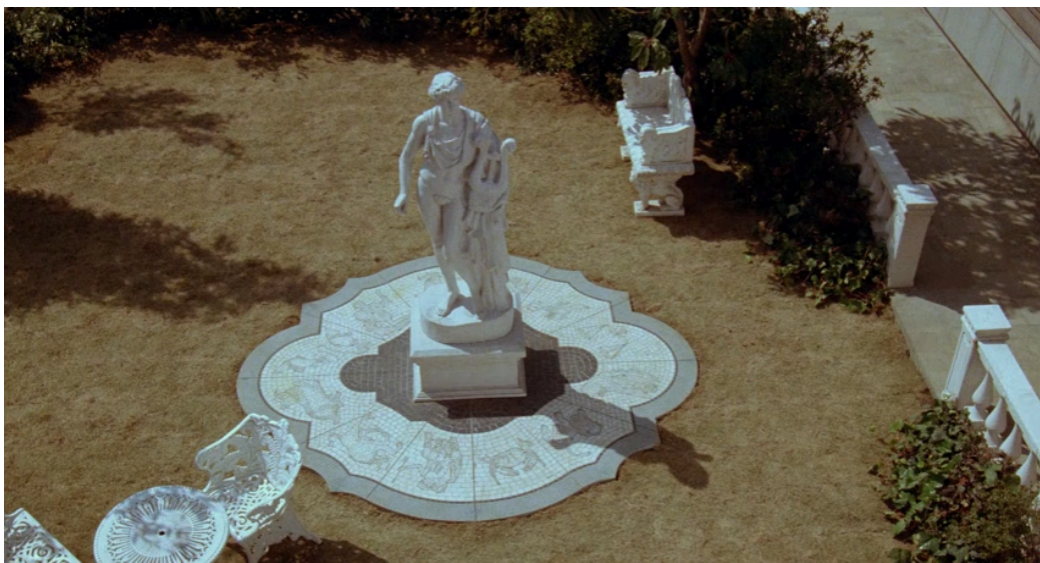


Behind the Statue (3:29)

The transition from the title card, “beauty,” directly to this sculpture at the center of both Mishima’s garden and the frame of the camera, immediately centers notions of a physical, sculpted and aesthetic masculinity at the heart of the film’s Mishima’s understanding of beauty. This relationship to the physical masculine form is reiterated in the second chapter of the film; after Mishima expresses to his friend, Akihiko Miwa, that he feels he isn’t beautiful because of his lack of masculine physical aesthetics, namely muscularity, Mishima visits Greece and narrates,

I’d always suffered under a monstrous sensitivity. What I lacked was health – a healthy body, a physical presence. Words had separated me from my body. The sun released me. Greece cured my self-hatred and awoke a will to health. I saw that beauty and ethics were one and the same. Creating a beautiful work of art and becoming beautiful oneself are identical. (Mishima 47:56-48:24).

For Mishima, to pursue physical aesthetics as a goal in itself is ethical, and in order to live ethically one must sculpt themselves according to an idealized, elevated beauty. The fit masculine body becomes a representation crafted of and by an ethical spirit.



In Front of the Statue (3:36)

However, this line also gestures towards Mishima's relationship with his body up until this point; he lacked health growing up, which for him denied an embodied physical presence, while representation, separate from his body, exacerbated this disembodiment. As a child in the film, young Mishima gazes through a window at other children play-fighting with sticks out on the street. He describes himself as "a boy leaning at the window... forever watching a world I was unable to change, forever hoping it would change by itself," (Mishima 8:36-8:46). Here Mishima looks through and below the window which mediates him from this lower physical world. This world, which he lacked the embodied agency to change, is also notably characterized by violent role-play of young boys. This establishes Mishima's initial relationship to physical masculinity, one in which the masculine is ultimately determined by physical prowess and he is, by default, othered from that masculinity by his illness.



Mishima at the Window (8:45)

This conception of masculinity is further evidenced by Junko Saeki's consideration of the masculine dynamic at work between the narrator of Mishima's semi-autobiographical *Confessions of a Mask*, "I", and his love-interest, Omi:

It is Omi, or more precisely, Omi's body that demonstrates the meaning of "life-force" to the narrator, who is always plagued by his lack of masculine strength. Physical weakness was disgusting, not only to "I", but also to the other boys, for it was considered "feminine" by them who were expected to grow up to be "masculine" (128-9).

Here, masculinity is seen to be deeply bound up with physical strength and health, whereas femininity, through opposition, is seen as the lack of these masculinity qualities. This topology of gender binds the narrator of Mishima's semi-autobiographical novel, and Schrader's Mishima to the feminine, wherein they're excluded from the world of the masculine because of their "feminine" bodies; young Mishima is reduced to a masculine observer trapped in an "effeminized" body, unable to take part in the world himself.

Young Mishima, however, is called away from this window, his view into the physical world, and is told to close the curtain by his grandmother. His grandmother, who took him in at seven weeks because of his illness, then guilts Mishima into staying with her to care for her health, instead of visiting his distant mother. She calls him a "delicate plant" who "must not go outdoors," further stressing Mishima's distance from an embodied reality. In return for taking care of her, "She entertained [Mishima] with stories and provided playmates. On special occasions, she arranged trips to the theater," (Mishima 9:59-11:17). Mishima's confinement from the physical world and care for his grandmother was rewarded with representations of worlds to fill in that lack. He remained physically distant from reality, yet the "stage made everything more beautiful. It turned men into women. It transformed the entire world," (Mishima 12:01-12:07).

Representations and constructions of reality could transform the world, if only momentarily, despite the fact that Mishima himself lacked the physical fitness to engage with the real world as such. This lack of masculinity that isolated Mishima from physical reality could also be overturned by the world of the stage, wherein he could identify as a man *or* a woman, no longer stuck in-between.

For Mishima later in life, observing the stage merely as an audience member proved insufficient; to truly connect his elevated, masculine spirit to reality, Mishima began to body-build. His ethical-aesthetic notions of body-building, of crafting a fit masculine body, wherein the observing self fashions the body according to an elevated beauty, is also briefly reflected by the changing elevation of the camera in the opening shots. At first, we start on the ground, alongside the sculpture of Apollo at the center. We sit in the position of the garden, in the viewable aesthetic and physical world, that can be looked-down upon from above. And after a shot of the garden grounds, we are now above the sculpture of Apollo, looking down at him. Our position as viewers is embodied and subsequently disembodied, establishing a spatial logic and hierarchy that reflects the ethical conception Mishima holds of beauty and masculinity. This statue of Apollo also carries the symbolic significance of classical aesthetics Mishima deeply identified with while in Greece: “It is implied that [Mishima] apprehended that in the Apollonian aesthetics of the antique human sculptures, was something that transcended the beauty of words, which he had to achieve in his own body with the aid of body building,” (Güven 1131). In order for Mishima to move beyond the ordered representation of words, the body must become an aesthetic sculpture to be fashioned according to “higher” ethical principles, like the elevated gaze of the camera.

This elevated gaze is central to Mishima's narcissistic relationship to the male body, wherein the physical becomes a projection of his ethical-aesthetic ideals. Later in chapter two, we see Mishima directing a photoshoot of himself in his garden. The voiceover narration, provided by Mishima, expresses that, "A writer is a voyeur par excellence. I came to detest this position. I sought to be not only the seer but also the seen," (Mishima 59:50-1:00:03). Writing and representations for Mishima, were nothing more than pure observation, detached from the physical reality of the self, like the overhead shot of the statue resting above the physical world of the garden, or like Mishima looking out the window. As he stated on his trip to Greece, words had separated him from his body. Yet his embodiment here occurs not only through the physical engagement of body-building as a negation of disembodied words; his body is directed by this observing gaze, which sculpts it according to idealistic aesthetic principles. Mishima's philosophy of body and spirit culminates in this narcissistic gaze, wherein Mishima becomes an Apollonian sculpture in his own garden.



Mishima in his Garden (59:44)

After the first few shots of this garden in chapter one, we enter Mishima's bedroom and watch him wake up and prepare for his final day. The first shot we get of this preparation is him shaving in the mirror. Despite the banality of the action, the blade raised to the skin presents an eerie parallel to his suicide later in the film. During Mishima's seppuku, the katana that is about to behead him is held at his eyeline, like a mirror, by his second-in-command, Morita, while Mishima holds a shorter blade up to his stomach. In both scenes his gaze is mirrored while he readies a blade against himself. His mode of engaging with his body is distanced from the body itself and capable of sculpting the physical, like the elevated view of the Apollo sculpture in his garden. These connections put the idea of masculine self-fashioning into conversation with his final action, where Mishima's guiding principles directly shape the performance of his life, from shaving to his eventual self-execution.



Mishima Shaving (4:38)

Returning to the photoshoot scene, Mishima further elaborates on the connections between the performance of masculinity and death. As the shoot goes on, Mishima narrates, “Men wear masks to make themselves beautiful. But unlike a woman’s, a man’s determination to

become beautiful is always a desire for death,” (Mishima 1:00:16-1:00:26). While this narration plays, the camera jumps between static shots of posters of Mishima performing hypermasculinity, with titles like “THE TOUGH GUY,” or “THE ASSASSINS.” In these posters he dons the mask of death-obsessed hypermasculinity, thus striving for his definition of masculine beauty. Miwa had also been noted to believe that, “Mishima’s transformation of his body stemmed from his long term desire to commit suicide. His hypermasculine body was one of a number of masks Mishima cultivated throughout his life.” (Jannarone 101-2). Physical masculinity, and the crafting of the body, is itself a mask that Mishima identifies with in order to achieve his lifetime goal of suicide.



Katana at his Eyeline (1:55:55)

This deep-seeded drive towards death, which leads Mishima towards hypermasculine fetishization, is further established by the film cutting away from these posters to Mishima’s recreation of his initial encounter with the erotic: a painting of the martyrdom of St. Sebastian, with his body bound to a tree and pierced with arrows. When Mishima narrates his initial encounter with St. Sebastian as a child in the first chapter of the film, he describes the arousal it

awakes in him, only to end in the claim that his “need to change reality was an urgent necessity, as important as three meals a day or sleep,” (Mishima 19:13-19:17). In this scene, three core components of Mishima’s identity are synthesized into a greater whole: his libidinal drives, his fetishization of death and its link with masculine aesthetics, and his urge to transform reality, akin to the powers of theater. Mishima’s photographic recreation of this painting later in the film extends his obsession with death, control, and the development of auto-eroticism through the sculpting gaze, wherein Mishima finds pleasure in the craft and performance of his own death.



Encounter with St. Sebastian (18:50)

But if Mishima’s fixation on the aesthetics of hypermasculinity grew from his eroticization of death, what facilitated the development of this drive in young Mishima? According to Danielle Bergeron, the death drive can be formulated in Lacanian terms as a striving for the “primordial real” that’s absent from, yet created by, the signifying chain of language, which organizes the subject in response to the trauma of the lack of the real, (183). Instead of accepting the real as an inexhaustible, unknowable other,

This invisible tattooing of the flesh by word/law henceforth becomes the source of the drive, the inexhaustible energy and the constant force which will endlessly aim at a reunion with the lost object causing the energy, in the mad hope that the energy created by the signifier corroding the organism, the death drive, will at last be exhausted. (183).

This kind of death drive can be thought of as a sort of fetishization of a lack: a manifestation of the never-present object of desire, *objet a*: “a so-called reuniting object, an inadequate hallucination,” which the subject believes will allow them to cross the gap between subject and object constructed by language, (184). The death of the subject at the hands of the fetish object is believed to allow them to access the “primordial real” which, in truth, “has never existed” as anything other than “an imposter representative of the impossible representation,” (184). We can already start to see the connections between Mishima’s ethical-aesthetic philosophy of body-building, his urgent need to transform reality, and the drive’s goal of reuniting the subject with the world of the body, othered by language.

Mishima’s childhood, as previously noted, was one in which he felt severed from his body, and captured by language and representations. In the film, as young Mishima is seen on a playground after he leaves his grandmother’s side and enters middle school, our narrator, Mishima, states that,

In my earliest years, I realized life consisted of two contradictory elements. One was words, which could change the world. The other was the world itself, which had nothing to do with words. For the average person, the body precedes language. In my case words came first. (Mishima 13:29-13:52).

Here Mishima establishes his personal understanding of the very barrier between subject and object. Words are constructs that allow for the transformation and construction of reality, akin to

the transformative power of theater, yet the real has nothing to do with language. In fact, it exists purely in negation of it, and is inaccessible via language except as the hallucination of a fetishized real. For Mishima then, whose language precedes body, his embodiment is undercut so thoroughly by language that he is completely othered from reality; he pursues it through the performance of body-building and eventual his suicide.

But what severed Mishima so deeply from his own flesh that he should strive towards death in order to reunite subject and object? Bergeron goes on to note that the frequently ill, young Mishima's relationship with his grandmother was one in which she "exploited him openly and freely," taking total control of his body and agency, misusing "her power over the child for the sake of her own jouissance," (185). His internal experience, between his illness and controlling grandmother, was invaded by the "jouissance of the Other," which manifested itself as "a death drive ceaselessly setting traps for the well-being of his organism," (185). His body was "parceled out by the searing return of the death drive through the letters that bore the marks and the persistent open wounds of the imaginary Other's jouissance," and these wounds of othered trauma were incapable of representation in language (186). Thus, Mishima began to fetishize these disorganizing, traumatic sensations of the Other, to "respond to the Other's jouissance in the hope of being freed from it," (186). The pain and trauma of the Other, both of his illness and his controlling grandmother, became central to his organization of self-hood; the trauma of the real that defined his childhood became fetishized as a means to reunite his severed and disorganized subjectivity with the body he lacked control over. To die on his own terms, to inflict the trauma of the real upon himself, would reunite the subject with the hallucinated object of primordial reality.



Recreation of St. Sebastian (1:00:37)

Mishima's recreation of the image of St. Sebastian acquires new meaning here: through fetishization of the image of martyrdom, he accepts the fundamental trauma of the real, the Other, in order to react to it. For Mishima, as stated directly before his recreation of St. Sebastian, this ability to wear a mask in pursuit of death, is innately masculine. The muscularity of the body as a mask is also central to Mishima's construction of a beautiful masculine death, as detailed in *Sun and Steel*:

A powerful, tragic frame and sculpturesque muscles were indispensable in a romantically noble death. Any confrontation between weak, flabby flesh and death seemed to me absurdly inappropriate...I lacked, in short, the muscles suitable for a dramatic death. And it deeply offended my romantic pride that it should be this unsuitability that had permitted me to survive the war. (27-8).

In order to die properly as a martyr, Mishima believed that the body should reject the "feminine" characteristics of a lack of muscularity, and should be crafted according to his ethical-aesthetic principles of reasoned strength: the ability to face the Other.

To concretize this conception of masculine martyrdom, Kant's definition of the dynamic sublime is quite helpful:

Might, is an ability that is superior to great obstacles. It is called *dominance* [Gewalt] if it is superior even to the resistance of something that itself possesses might. When in an aesthetic judgement we consider nature as a might that has no dominance over us, then it is *dynamically sublime*. (119).

In this conception of the *dynamic sublime*, the force of *might*, which allows for the *dominance* over other mights, can carry a sublime quality when it is applied to nature. If we can consider, in Mishima's case, Kant's nature as a figure for the trauma of the real, then Mishima is striving actively for a sublime encounter with the Other, wherein auto-erotic aesthetics permits him the ability to see himself capable of matching death. For Mishima, his ability to organize himself as an ethical masculine subject relies on the performance of might through dynamically sublime bodily aesthetics; this ethical-aesthetic organization necessarily hinges on the confrontation with the Other: death.

The first major obstacle that the film's Mishima had to organize himself around in order to strive towards this fetishized might of masculine martyrdom was the "effemine" weakness of his body. Between his illness and his controlling grandmother, the "effeminizing" force of the Other had severed his masculine subjectivity from his body. The invasion of the Other's jouissance had jabbed a wedge in the symbolic organization of his masculine identification. In the novel which is adapted into the fictional section of the first chapter of the film, *The Temple of the Golden Pavillion*, the mother of the protagonist, Mizoguchi, as well as other women in the novel are noted by Rio Otomo to act as "the archaic authority that threatens (instead of mediating) his entry into the symbolic," (279). Whereas symbolic law for Mizoguchi is

represented by “by the dead father, the Superior of the temple, and the images of Kinkakuji,” which embody a “pure-and-clean” spiritual reality (279). Symbolic masculine identification is found through purity and order, akin to Mishima’s own Apollonian ethical-aesthetic notions of a “higher” masculinity. On the other hand, the feminine in *The Temple of the Golden Pavillion* stands in the way of this and represents exactly its Dionysian opposite:

She is the source of evil and the cause of tragedy. At the same time, however, she governs the reality that brooding Mizoguchi struggles to get in touch with. She represents the outside world that is the object of his repressed desire. (281)

Anything that separates Mizoguchi or Mishima from the symbolic order of ethical-aesthetic masculinity is identified as the traumatic Other and effeminized to maintain the borders of masculine identification.

This feminine and traumatic Other is represented in the film’s second chapter, during the adaptation of *Kiyoko’s House*. During the beginning of the film’s version of *Kikyoko’s House*, the chosen protagonist of the adaptation, Osamu, “a handsome, flirtatious, narcissistic actor,” lays in bed with an unnamed woman he’s just slept with (Güven 1131). The scene begins with a sheer top-sheet resting over his face and his eyes are held closed; he seems dead. The room is lit in a two-tone pink, a fictionalized intense neon-light moving in from the outside. His face, at first masked only by the top-sheet, is then doubly obscured by the back of his lover’s head, as her face approaches his. She removes the cloth, his eyes open, and they start to talk. Already, the seemingly lifeless male body of Osamu is surrounded by a feminine, overwhelmingly pink, atmosphere. This pink neon light that leaks into the building seemingly collapses the boundaries of inside and outside, reflecting the invasive jouissance of the Other. This is only further strengthened by the way her shadow and face cover Osamu from our point of view, as she leans

in to kiss him. The environment itself, the real that surrounds Osamu's body, is effeminized; through blurring of inside and outside and Osamu's lifelessness, he is completely subjected to the feminine Other.



Osamu Lifeless (42:54)

As the scene goes on, he asks her whether or not his legs would look good in tights, wherein she responds by talking about her nails, and he remains fixed on his legs, with the camera focusing on them from his perspective. Osamu thinks out-loud that he pays “too much attention to [his] face, but what about [his] body? If only [he] were more muscular, like a matador. Then [his] whole body could be [his] face,” (Mishima 43:27-43:40). His lover laughs in response to this, calling it unrealistic, yet he remains unaffected, staring up at the ceiling briefly lost in this masculine fantasy. This sentiment of body as face resembles Mishima's own consideration of the masculine body as a mask; from thinking about how his legs will look on-stage, Osamu considers his body as an aesthetic performance capable of representing his self-fashioned conception of identity, like a mask donned by an actor.

After dismissing Osamu's desire to start body-building, his lover then mounts him, and steals the mirror he's using to admire his own face with. She says, "I'll be your mirror," and the camera takes the position of her gaze, looking down at Osamu from above, (Mishima 44:39). Osamu remains still, eyes wide open, as she covers his body with the mirror, reflecting her form back up at the camera instead, cutting Osamu's body into feminine parts. As the scene comes to an end, she says, "See? Isn't this better than a mirror?" (Mishima 45:04). At this moment, Osamu is completely organized according to the desire of the feminine Other. His mirror, and ability to fashion himself according to a masculine symbolic identity, is threatened by this overwhelming atmosphere of femininity, akin to Mishima's gendered relationship with his grandmother. Osamu, contrasting to Mishima, seemingly accepts this effeminized position, subject to the organizing gaze and jouissance of the Other, shutting his eyes, returning to the state of death in which he started the scene, as it ends.



Osamu Reorganized (45:10)

The oppressive atmosphere of the feminine Other as seen in Kiyoko's House, might also be helpful in understanding Mishima's relationship to capitalist modernity. Returning to the opening scene, directly following Mishima shaving in front of the mirror, we watch him reading the morning paper, sipping espresso, and overlooking the city from his estate. The camera starts below his body, then cuts to look over his shoulder as he reads, and back just below his eyeline before gazing out over the sprawling cityscape. The hierarchy of the gaze again begins to imply a sort of spatial logic of ethics and aesthetics: the elevated subject looks down on the object which it attempts to organize. However, the camera slowly zooms in on the city, and we become enveloped by the space of modern Japan. The scene cuts and transitions directly to Mishima preparing and donning his Shield Society uniform, the clothing he had personally designed for his own private militia, and for his suicide.



Postwar Japan (5:05)

This quick transition creates a symbolic, causal linkage, wherein the overwhelming atmosphere of modern Japan that seemingly engulfs the space of the camera “causes” Mishima's preparation of his far-right performance. According to Kimberly Jannarone, from the 1960s to

his death, Mishima was in favor of far-right nationalistic politics due to his beliefs that the “reduction of the military’s powers was a serious threat to traditional Japanese values in a postwar Japan dominated by Western consumerism,” (96). His infamous attempted coup-d’etat and suicide “were performances of virility designed to make a public statement of resistance to the increasingly westernized, materialistic Japan,” (97). These priorities, through the interest in militarization and virility, are already riddled with Mishima’s conception of physical masculinity; in turn, postwar Japan could be seen as lacking masculine qualities, therefore, typologized as feminine. This brief scene of Mishima looking out over the city that devours his gaze, through its transition to the donning of the Shield Society’s uniform, quickly establishes Mishima’s death-bound performance of militaristic and masculine virility as a response and reaction to this “effeminized” and materialistic, postwar culture. His suicide on the political stage takes on the same form of sublime resistance to an effeminized Other which seemingly jeopardizes his symbolic organization of masculinity; he recreates his fetish of St. Sebastian in the social sphere.

However, his ethical-aesthetic ideals that look down on the physical world from above are still totally enveloped by the atmosphere of modern Japan; Mishima “never harbored any delusions that his coup d’etat would be successful,” yet he still believed that this suicide mission and self-fashioned performance “was necessary to remind the Japanese people of their national identity and purpose,” (Jannarone 97, 116). He lacked the real power to change or mold the contemporary political climate, so he turned his gaze towards himself, something he could sculpt, to perform as a masculine symbol of rebellion against the othered postwar Japan. The action of suicide, already relevant as part of Mishima’s fetish, simultaneously operates as an ideological device given the fact that “Corporate greed defeated Mishima’s aesthetic of Eros and Thanatos,” (Jannarone 109). Corporatization and capitalism was in direct conflict with

Mishima's conception of death-driven masculine identity, directly hampering his symbolic organization. In order to reject the social conditions of modernity that threatened his masculinity, Mishima died to keep the very concept of a sublime masculine death alive in social reality; he attempted to cement his ideals in reality through performance, to use theater to transform the world and to make himself a man.



Mishima's Reflected Gaze (6:35)

We can see this logic continued by the film's opening scene as Mishima begins to button up his Shield Society uniform in front of a mirror. At first, the camera is positioned behind Mishima, looking into the mirror along with him. But as he begins to dress, the camera flips, and watches Mishima from the perspective of the mirror itself akin to the organizing gaze of the lover in *Kyoko's House*, yet this is still Mishima's reflected gaze. His gaze and self operates in this split position, where his body is a vehicle for his performative ideology, organized and fashioned by his mirroring, self-reflexive gaze. The camera continues to occupy the perspective of the mirror as Mishima places his Shield Society cap on. It then cuts back to looking at his reflection; in black and white, images of Mishima's reflection in a Noh mask, Kendo mask, and

pilot's mask flash in rapid succession. The fact that we view these masks from the side of the physical world, not the reflexive gaze, is important since it posits Mishima's physical reality as just another imaginary mask donned in the face of an oppressive Other; he performs his imaginary ideals in reality to maintain them, and his masculinity, against the disorganizing, modern and feminine Other.



Imaginary Pilot's Mask (6:39)

The cut to black and white here also presents the first moment in which the film starts to complicate its diegesis relating to the color-film, detailed realism of the present day. Black and white, as a mode in the film, is specifically used to represent Mishima's past. This mode could in some ways be considered an interior perspective, since it is used to represent Mishima's memories; this is further confirmed by Mishima's first-person narration of the events, as well as the transition to the past from the present in the second chapter, "art," wherein Mishima looks down an alleyway only to transition directly to the past, as though he's the one looking into or imagining it (Mishima 27:28-27:34). In this first black and white moment during his morning

routine, despite being on the side of physical reality, we have the images of his interiority seemingly leaking through into the real, yet remaining partially separated from the reality of the film through the black and white mode. The mask of his physical body in this moment is both a protection and reaction to reality, but also Mishima's interiority attempting to make itself just as real as the world and Other he is responding to.

The indistinct screams and noises that play in the background also break the constrained realism of the film's diegesis. This audio seemingly signals Mishima's closeness with death in this moment, especially since this auditory lapse in realism only happens twice: this scene and the one leading up to his ritual suicide. The closeness to death here is relevant in relation to collapsing bounds of diegesis; in a scene where Mishima recounts his memory of flying in a fighter jet before he goes on to commit suicide, he states that, "Somewhere there must be a higher principle that reconciles art and action. That principle, it occurred to me, was death," (Mishima 1:49:37-1:49:47). Art and action, to Mishima, are a dualistic pair that resists synthesis: "Never in physical action had I discovered the chilling satisfaction of words. Never in words had I experienced the hot darkness of action," yet through death, the chilling sensation of language and symbolic organization could meaningfully manifest itself in the hot, dark, experience of the real (Mishima 1:49:20-1:49:31). Death to Mishima, is the means by which his masculine ethical-aesthetic ideals can express themselves in physical reality; this brief lapse in the continuity of diegesis as Mishima contemplates his near-death reflects this philosophy through the form of the film.

To further understand the reality defying performance of death, the elaborate planning of Mishima's suicide could in a lot of ways be considered a kind of art or fiction, especially considering the fact that Mishima understood the coup would accomplish nothing. After

Mishima finalizes his preparations for his final day in the opening scene, putting on his gloves and placing his weapons necessary for seppuku away in a suitcase, he calls a journalist to ask him, “Did you get my letter? Don’t worry, you’ll find our little drama newsworthy. And bring a photographer,” (Mishima 7:46-7:54). The explicit planning of this event as a media spectacle already suffuses it with a charge of virtuality and performance. According to Richard Schechner, the 9/11 attacks shared a similar structure, which put them in conversation with the Western conception of avant-garde performance aesthetics:

And art is not as serious as politics; art is play, secondary, a representation. However, from the perspective of performance studies, the attack on the World Trade Center was a performance: planned, rehearsed, staged, and intended both to wound the United States materially and to affect and infect the imagination. (1825).

This conception of violence as performance gets at the heart of the virtuality of Mishima’s own performance; the act of seppuku for Mishima was akin to play, to theater, to a scripted enactment and (re)presentation of his own fantasies. Death, however, allowed for this performance to have traumatic material consequences, and to become “art that is action, not representation,” mirroring Mishima’s own sentiments of a harmony of pen and sword (1826).

For Mishima then, death operates as a traumatic punctum that cleaves open the boundaries between the chilling interior fantasy of the subject and the hot darkness of the reality that has nothing to do with subjectivity. This sentiment naturally has structural similarities to his own fetishization of death: a means to bridge the gap between himself and the traumatic Other he subjugates himself to, despite resisting its invasion and disorganization of his sublime, symbolic masculinity. This punctum collapses the difference between the symbolic and the real, but could also be considered a transgression of the symbolic and imaginary *into* the domain of the real; art

oversteps its prohibitions as pure play through death. Here, George Bataille's concept of the dialectics of transgression helps to contextualize this process:

As soon as human beings give rein to animal nature in some way we enter the world of transgression forming the synthesis between animal nature and humanity through the persistence of the taboo; we enter a sacred world, a world of holy things. (84).

Animalistic nature is able to “escape the rule of taboos and remain open to the violence (the excess, that is) that reigns in the realms of death and reproduction,” (83). The boundary of art as pure play here acts as this kind of taboo which separates human from animal, which allows humanity to consider themselves “free from the excessive domination of death and reproductive activity,” (83). Art that transgresses this taboo synthesizes the animalistic violence of reality with the symbolic organization of humanity; it brings the hot excess of reality into the domain of human expression which allows it to transcend the human limits of art and play. Art transgresses its domain and becomes sublime action.

This image is especially clear during the adaptation of Mishima's novel, *Runaway Horses*, a story about a group of young men who plot the assassination of a group of capitalists, only to be discovered and imprisoned. At the end of the film's adaptation, Isao, the leader of this coup, escapes his jail cell and assassinates the capitalist Kurahara. How he assassinates him is especially important: Isao cuts through an exposed painting that has no wall behind it, letting him into the room that Kurahara is currently lounging in. Isao symbolically transgresses the boundaries of representation and reality in a visually metaleptic fashion, and kills Kurahara. He then escapes back through the hole in the painting, to find that the sun has begun to rise. The turn to morning is visualized through the trees, rocks, and bushes surrounding Isao turning a deep red,

potentially representing the transgression of violent art into the domain of the real, literally transforming it through performance.



Visual Metalepsis (1:29:17)

As the opening scene of the film concludes, we return to the garden from a similar position as the first shot of the scene, in the back, seeing the Apollo sculpture from behind. However, this time the camera is raised, looking down on the garden and Mishima leaving his estate. When the shot starts, Mishima is notably higher than the statue from the perspective of the camera. Yet as the scene goes on, the camera moves closer to the statue, allowing it to take up more of the frame, growing taller, while Mishima descends the staircase to exit his home, falling below the height of the statue as the scene ends. This shot, playing on the established spatial logic of the garden, presents Mishima as incapable of truly achieving a transcendental subjectivity. His body, his real self, is always lower than the fantasy of his sculpting gaze, harking back to the fact that his hypermasculine mask and performance, like the black and white masks in the mirror, are only imaginary constructions of self. Despite his use of death in

performance as a transcendental mode of self-expression, that transcendence is still pure fantasy, trapped in the world of a disorganized subjectivity.



Mishima Descending (8:28)

The film itself ends at the point of Mishima's suicide, refusing us access to the world outside of his own perception, experience, and performance. As he shoves the blade into his stomach, we see the death-driven climaxes of each of the film's adaptations of his work, returning to the assassin, Isao, whose suicide by seppuku is cut away from initially in chapter 3 and instead shown here at the end of the film, where Mishima attempts to blur art and reality. Mishima narrates this event as the film ends: "The instant the blade tore open his flesh, the bright disk of the sun soared up behind his eyelids and exploded, lighting the sky for an instant," (Mishima 1:56:47-1:56:53). The distinction that the sun lights the sky from inside his eyelids points at the core of Mishima's sacrifice: the purely imaginary nature of it. While Mishima was certainly able to attract public attention and cement himself in history as some sort of martyr, that martyrdom was itself just an imaginary reaction to the trauma of reality, which is in itself also an imaginary construction.



Isao's Suicide (1:56:53)

Mishima's search for the real, and the ability to unite his subjectivity with it through performance ultimately ends inside of a fiction, inside his narcissistic subjectivity. In his initial consideration of the sublime, Kant notes that:

Instead, all we are entitled to say is that the object is suitable for exhibiting a sublimity that can be found in the mind. For what is sublime, in the proper meaning of the term, cannot be contained in any sensible form but concerns only ideas of reason, which, though they cannot be exhibited adequately, are aroused and called to mind by this very inadequacy, (99).

The sublime is only an object of the mind, one that cannot be adequately imagined, only signified through reason or language. Given this lack, akin to the subject's fundamental lack of the Other, Mishima's performance of sublime masculinity and transcendental performance of death was incapable of truly manifesting his fantasy in reality. The self-reflexive gaze that

dominates Mishima's psychic experience remains trapped above, yet still inside, the subject, and ultimately dies alongside it, leaving Mishima subjugated to the traumatic Other he desperately tried to will against.

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